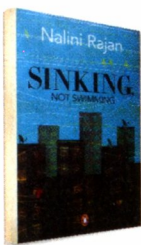
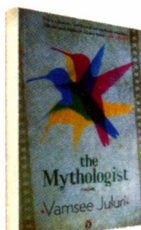


Secrets and LIES

Unhappy families are unhappy in their own distinct ways. Two books show how.



SINKING, NOT SWIMMING
by NALINI RAJAN
Penguin India
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 254



THE MYTHOLOGIST
by VAMSEE JULURI
Penguin India
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 269

By Janice Parlat

Funerals provide rich fodder for numerous literary landscapes. Far from merely being an event of burial or cremation, a funeral throws up conflicts and remembrances of all kinds. This has been explored from as long back as 422 B.C., with Sophocles' *Antigone*, a story of an epic battle of wills between Creon, King of Thebes, and Antigone over the funeral rites of her brother Polynices. James Joyce uses a funeral as the main event of Leopold Bloom's day in *Ulysses*. Closer home, Arundhati Roy's *God of Small Things* opens with the death of Sophie Mol, an event that drastically affects all the characters' lives. Nalini Rajan's *Sinking, Not Swimming* closely resembles Anne Enright's 2007 Booker-winning novel *The Gathering*, in that a funeral brings together often estranged family members, stirring up a deep well of grief and emotion.

Unlike Enright's book, however, which progresses towards the uncovering of a terrible family secret, *Sinking, Not Swimming* has no particular plot structure, and is strung together by a montage of voices. Cheenu, beloved father and husband, has died after a desperate fight with cancer, and the people around him struggle to come to terms with this. The narratives alternate between characters and make for some confusing reading in the initial stages. The reader, thrown into the thick of things, must grasp names and relationships—Suri is Cheenu's jealous elder brother, Ravi is the laidback, drunken nephew, Paru is the risqué sister-in-law, Akhila the brilliant but frustrated scientist married to Suresh, Cheenu's lecherous relative, Jagan is the young, cheeky grand-nephew. It doesn't help that Rajan's prose offers no distinct style between these voices—apart from making Jagan say “youthful” things like “man”, “cool” and “fuck”. That said, however, the narrative sections by Cheenu's wife Meena, are probably the most moving and convincing. Here, she speaks of how she stopped cooking spinach pulao because the two times she did, Cheenu was rushed to the hospital, or how she

nursed the potted plant in the balcony hoping it would mean her husband getting better as well, or how she would wear red and green saris because they were lucky. Apart from this, perhaps the biggest, and only, strength of the book is in the petty details—the things that family members know about each other, the dirty little secrets, the trivial jealousies, the thwarted ambitions. This is a time when skeletons rattle loudly in the closet, and unspoken things are blurred in anger.

Vamsee Juluri's *The Mythologist* is also about families but of the kind that may not actually be related by blood. While the story does not centre around a funeral of any kind, there runs through the narrative a constant strain of loss. The protagonist, Parashuram, has been abandoned by his parents—“All I remember of my parents are the backs of their heads and the smell of Brylcreem from my

